

What to Expect When You're Inspecting

Here's how it all goes down. The inspector arrives at the house, sets up any long-term tests (like radon, mold, or meth), and then starts the formal inspection. They will work from an extensive checklist so they don't miss anything, and they will take pictures to include in their report. They'll inspect every inch of the house, including the roof, either climbing up on it or using a fancy drone to take pictures of it. When the inspector is finished, they will walk the entire house again to show you, the buyer, everything they found during the inspection.

From start to finish, this entire process takes about four hours—excluding any long-term tests, which might need to be set up for days to get an accurate reading.

Though you don't need to be there for the entire four hours, you should be there for the last hour if at all possible. Why? If the inspector is as good as they should be, they're in multiple homes every week. Though your house is fresh in their mind while they're doing their job, it's not impossible that they'll forget it as soon as they walk out the door. They've seen so many houses that they all start to blur together, so the best time to ask your inspector for information about the house is while they're still in the house. And trust us, you'll want to ask a lot of questions.

Home inspectors have a knack for making trivial repairs seem huge and huge repairs seem trivial. If the inspector mentions something you aren't familiar with, consider asking, "Is that a ten-dollar fix or a ten-thousand-dollar fix?" While your inspector won't be able to provide you with an accurate repair quote, they can let you know if what you're looking at is an expensive fix or a manageable one.

As you're walking around the property, ask questions. And keep asking until you understand the answer. Like we said above, once that inspector is gone, they most likely won't remember the ins and outs of the home, so make sure all your questions are answered to your satisfaction on the spot.

Your final question to the inspector should be, "What is your opinion of the condition of this home? Would you let your mother buy it?" A good inspector won't hesitate to tell you their honest opinion. We've heard some astonishing stories of inspectors who look the buyer right in the eye and say, "Walk away from this house. It's a disaster." While you might not get such a direct response from your inspector, the tone and content of their